PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #76 · SUBSTANCE ABUSE

“A little doesn’t count. I can keep it small and still be in control.”

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Where it often comes from

“A little doesn’t count” is how a lot of people stay out of the conversation. If it is small, it is not a problem, and you are still in control. Sometimes the amount really is small. The lie is the rule that small means harmless, and that you can keep it small forever by deciding to. You do not need a dramatic story to be allowed to get help. You also do not need to call yourself a terrible person because the amount was not huge. Honesty about the little is an act of care, not a confession that you are worthless. If you want help, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357. Do not try to stop or withdraw on your own if that could make you sick. A doctor can help you do it safely, and a counselor can walk with you. Needing that help is not a failure.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says that not everything is beneficial, and “I will not be mastered by anything.” He is not sorting people into the ruined and the fine. He is telling the truth that a permitted thing can still take the lead. You do not know what tomorrow brings, so “I will keep it small” is a hope, not a guarantee. You can ask God for help before a little becomes the master. Jesus sets people free. Your help comes from the Lord. None of this requires you to exaggerate the problem or to hide it.

> *“‘Everything is permissible for me,’ but not everything is beneficial. ‘Everything is permissible for me,’ but I will not be mastered by anything”* (1 Corinthians 6:12).

Also see

> “Do not boast about tomorrow, for you do not know what a day may bring” (Proverbs 27:1).

> “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need” (Hebrews 4:16).

> “So if the Son sets you free, you will be free indeed” (John 8:36).

> “I lift up my eyes to the hills. From where does my help come? My help comes from the LORD, the Maker of heaven and earth” (Psalm 121:1–2).

Common self-statements

- It is only a little. People are overreacting.
- I can keep it at this level forever.
- If I am not using as much as someone else, I do not need help.
- Admitting the little makes me a hypocrite.
- I am still in charge because I chose the amount.
- God does not care about something this small.

Common logical errors

- Minimization: Shrinking the pattern so you do not have to look at it.
- Comparison: Using someone else’s larger use as proof that yours does not count.
- All-or-nothing thinking: If it is not the worst case, it is nothing.
- Control fallacy: Believing that choosing the amount means the amount cannot start choosing you.

Challenging questions

- What do I mean by a little, and has that meaning already changed?
- What am I unwilling to give up, even in a small amount?
- Would I want a friend to get help at this stage, or only after a crisis?
- Am I more interested in keeping it small or in telling the truth?
- What would help look like before things grow?
- What does “not mastered by anything” invite, without a speech of shame?

Truth summary

> A little can still matter. I can be honest about it, and I can get help before I have to prove I lost control.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

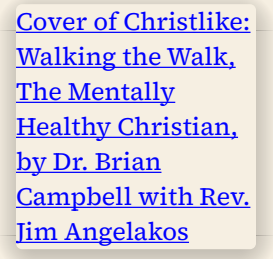
- Thinking, Healthy
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Help
- Faith
- Guilt/Shame

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Truth
- Prayer

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from “The Mentally Healthy Christian” (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
The voice that says a little does not count is worth testing.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
You can tell the truth about the little without turning it into a speech of shame.

More Than Conquerors — Steven Curtis Chapman
You do not have to be mastered by something you keep calling small.

Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus — Reawaken Hymns
Look at Christ, who offers freedom, when you are bargaining about amount.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

My Plan for Replacing "A little doesn't count. I can keep it small and still be in control."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"A little doesn't count. I can keep it small and still be in control." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What do I mean by a little, and has that meaning already changed?
- ☐ What am I unwilling to give up, even in a small amount?
- ☐ Would I want a friend to get help at this stage, or only after a crisis?
- ☐ Am I more interested in keeping it small or in telling the truth?
- ☐ What would help look like before things grow?
- ☐ What does "not mastered by anything" invite, without a speech of shame?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ A little can still matter. I can be honest about it, and I can get help before I have to prove I lost control.
- ☐ Small is not the same as harmless.
- ☐ I do not have to wait for a crisis to tell the truth.
- ☐ I am not worthless if a little has started to matter.
- ☐ I can ask whether this is mastering me.
- ☐ A doctor or a counselor can help me look at this without shaming me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 1 Corinthians 6:12
  "'Everything is permissible for me,' but not everything is beneficial. 'Everything is permissible for me,' but I will not be mastered by anything."
- ☐ Proverbs 27:1
  "Do not boast about tomorrow, for you do not know what a day may bring."
- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you said a little did not count: Each day, write down one moment when you kept the amount small in order to stay in control. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, 1 Corinthians 6:12 becomes: "James can write: "A little can still master me. I can tell the truth and ask for help.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Thinking, Healthy" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. For help with substance use, call 1-800-662-4357, and talk with a doctor before you stop if withdrawal could make you sick.

- [ ] Write the actual amount for the last seven days, plainly. No comparing it with someone worse, and no name-calling.
- [ ] Show that note to a doctor, a counselor, or tell it to 1-800-662-4357.
- [ ] Do not "prove it is small" by stopping suddenly if withdrawal could make you sick. Ask what is safe.
- [ ] Pray 1 Corinthians 6:12 as a request not to be mastered, not as a verdict.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "A little doesn't count. I can keep it small and still be in control.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A time I did not minimize the amount
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~A little doesn't count. I can keep it small and still be in control~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have said a little does not count. Give me honesty without shame, and help before this masters me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.